



For the people, of the people: "For me, it was about representing my school, city, and the wishes of more than a billion people in my country," says Paes. DEBASISH BHADURI

Slam, people said it was a fluke. Then I did it the second time, and they called it a fluke again. I won the four slams on all the surfaces after that, and it continued, and now I am sitting on 20 Slam titles. It was a humbling experience, and it was the determination to prove myself again and again that got me to the position where I stand now.

Champions are made of intelligence, grit, passion to live out big dreams, and the ability to stand up every time you fall. Champions are made of special stuff, and it is all out there in the mind. The ability to make a simple decision under pressure is what separates

champions from normal sportspersons. You can get lucky once, but repeating that success over and over again is what makes a champion.

By the time you travelled to Chennai at the age of 11, India had won a cricket World Cup in 1983 and Olympic medals in hockey. But what inspired you to take up tennis, which was then considered a niche sport?

I had a simple and single-minded dream, and that was to prove to the world that, as Indians, we could win Olympic medals in individual sports. We had medals in field hockey, but in individual sporting events, it was a long wait since KD Jadhav's bronze medal in 1952. There were no guidelines that could teach us how to win and be successful in an individual sport like tennis. So, becoming a pioneer in that field took great

hardships. I hitch-hiked through Europe, and I had to sleep in locker rooms as there was no money to book a hotel room. I was even mugged in New York, but those things only kept me going. It was a journey to be the only Indian on tour for a large part because, by then, Ramanathan Krishnan had retired, as had Vijay (Amritraj) and Ramesh (Krishnan). Before I picked Mahesh (Bhupathi) for doubles, there were no other Indians, so travelling alone on ATP tours was not easy.

That mugging episode in New York also left a scar on your chest. So, when things got difficult or lonely, did that scar remind you of your dream and ensure you did not give up?

Hundred per cent! I see that scar every single time I put on a match shirt. Every single night I went to bed, missing home, I reminded myself of